

BITF Temple Guardians Guidebook

Temple Guardians Philosophies

1) Invisible Stewardship

- a) You are embodying and transmitting certain energies through your mindset and intentions.
- b) You are creating a sacred container for people to experience something meaningful to them.

2) Gentle Interventions

- a) Intervene gently if you sense that help may be needed.
- b) Start by making your presence known in subtle ways before moving to direct communications.
- c) Get their consent to provide help whenever possible but make the call to intervene if needed.

Temple Guardian Mandate from Burning Man Site:

“We do not make rules, nor are we enforcers; we watch quietly and act skillfully when necessary to protect the safety and sacred space of the Temple. Most of all we provide the Temple with grounding and love. From our humble beginnings, we have always followed a philosophy that calls for using small pushes from a great distance. Sometimes your look, your soft words, or even just your presence is all that is required to hold the sacred space of the Temple. When we do interact with participants, we do so with love and respect.”

Temple Guardian Duties

1) Holding Sacred Space

Sacredness is a deep sense of reverence for the intrinsic value in all things. In many cultures and eras, the concept of sacredness has existed. With the help of deeper spiritual and scientific awareness, we are slowly awakening to a deeper respect for our planet, its inhabitants and its resources. As a Temple Guardian, you are helping to anchor this sense of reverence at the Temple.

There are many visible acts of reverence ranging from the practice of bowing, praying, chanting, lighting candles, making offerings, building temples, going on pilgrimages (road trips to a sacred site), making shrines, honoring the dead in graveyards, creating altars to conducting ceremonies. You may witness aspects of these practices at the Temple at BITF.

You can help set the mood and vibe by holding a sense of deep Respect, Compassion and Welcome for all the different people, their forms of expression and items they may leave in the Temple. This mindset will also guide you to take the most respectful action in different situations.

BITF Temple Guardians Guidebook

Here are some guidelines to keep in mind:

A) Allow people to choose how they wish to experience the temple. Do not interfere unless they are impacting the emotional and physical safety of the Temple and/or its visitors.

B) Leave people's altars and offerings as they are unless there is a safety issue or fire hazard. If someone moves an item and you're not sure that it's the person who left the item, please check in and if needed, discreetly remind them to respect an offering's placement.

C) Be a respectful witness of people's expressions and emotions. If you see grief or pain, try to gauge whether they need privacy to process or if they actually need help. When in doubt, approach gently and ask respectfully if they would like your help.

Through your invisible stewardship and gentle interventions, you are respectfully creating space for people to experience what they need in the Temple.

2) Offering Emotional Care

If someone seems to need something, you can quietly let them know you are available.

A) Begin with non-verbal cues like simply being visible from a distance to moving closer with a bow, a gentle smile or a kind look. Avoid using words, direct approach or touch in this first layer of stewardship.

B) As needed, you can step closer and begin discreet communication with gentle questions or an offer of assistance. Avoid giving unsolicited touch, advice or help unless you have consent or you see that the person's well-being or safety requires direct intervention.

C) At this point, identify yourself as a Temple Guardian and instead of making assumptions about their needs, ask them if they need help from you, Medics, Sanctuary or Rangers.

If someone opens up to you:

- 1) Let them know you will practice Confidentiality so they can safely open up to you.
- 2) Be attentive and listen deeply to understand them.
- 3) Be open-minded and receive what is shared but also honor your own needs or boundaries.
- 4) Be compassionate and if needed, reflect back what you think you've understood.
- 5) Be respectful of their autonomy and only offer help or suggestions as needed or requested.
- 6) If there is apparent danger or they feel unsafe, let them know you will stay with them as you radio and wait for rangers, sanctuary or medics to arrive.

BITF Temple Guardians Guidebook

3) Offering Physical Care

Self-Care First:

- 1) Do physical and emotional self-care! Be well-rested, hydrated and nourished for your shift.
- 2) Be sober for your shift and allow yourself some time to get grounded beforehand.
- 3) Ideally, do a site check before your shift to get familiar with the Temple's location and layout.
- 4) Review this guidebook and the Guardian Checklist before your shift.
- 5) Remember to prepare for and attend to your body's needs during your shift.

What to Wear and Bring:

- 1) Wear clothing that is comfortable, suitable for the weather and that cover private parts
- 2) Snacks, water, personal items that you may need (meds, eye drops or tissues etc)
- 3) Something to sit on for parts of your shift (blanket, pillow or camp chair)
- 4) Shade (hat, umbrella or sarong)
- 5) Small bag to pickup MOOP (matter out of place = small debris or trash)
- 6) Optional: DIY Guardian Care Kit (idea from AppleCat) containing tissues, note paper, pens, first-aid kit or bandages & any other supplies that you could offer to visitors if needed.

Review the Temple Guardian Logistics Document

This document contains the site map, shift Sign-in and sign-out details, temple tasks, commissary info, radio protocols and other last minute info that may arise so please read in full!

Physical Duties:

- 1) You will have a partner to collaborate and walk with on your 4-hour Temple Shift. (If only one person signs-in for a shift, they have the choice of doing the shift alone or cancelling.)
- 2) Generally, you will act like another visitor yet identify yourself when help may be needed.
- 3) Check that the structure is safe and that people are safe. Safety issues may include:
 - ~ Fire (for incense or candles, be on fire duty: extinguish properly and remind people of fire safety)
 - ~ Abuse, Violence, Assault, Sexual assault, Harassment, Bullying
 - ~ Lost Children or Parents looking for a lost child
 - ~ Medical or Psychiatric Emergency like injuries, illness or psy-crisis
 - ~ Climbing or damaging the structure of the Temple
 - ~ Physical or emotional endangerment to any visitor or volunteer

BITF Temple Guardians Guidebook

Physical Duties continued...

- 4) Be ready to provide assistance and gentle guidance but remember that you are not there to enforce rules or manage conflicts.
- 5) If you see behaviors that may impact the safety/sanctity of the Temple or visitors, approach as if they are your friends and offer them gentle reminders of the nature of this space. In your tone and energy, assume their innocence and good will rather than their guilt or resistance.
- 6) Keep the temple spaces available for everyone's use (no taking over the space for personal use).
- 7) If you face a situation that requires more help or intervention, please use the radio to call for help.
- 8) Gather small debris or trash in your moop bag. You can also prevent moop by helping people weigh down their altar items.

(One idea that someone suggested: gather a few stones from the area before your shift and place in a corner of the Temple to use when needed for weighing down altar items during your shift.)

REMEMBER YOUR MAIN MISSION:

You are the Invisible & Gentle Stewards at the Temple
You are there to hold a sacred space of Respect, Compassion & Care

Quote from Burning Man's Temple Guardian Guidebook:

"We do not police, we suggest and remind people of where they are
and what the space means to the community."

**Thank you so much for your loving service
at the BITF Temple!**